

CHAPTER 3 km — requested variables that are not directly available

Date: 2026-09-16 · **Scope:** the variable list requested for the CHAPTER regional reanalysis (atmosphere, static, land-surface, ocean waves, sea ice, surface ocean). This note answers one question: of the variables you asked for, which ones can we actually put in the GRIB archive, which ones we can obtain by some other route, and which ones are simply not in the data. It is meant to be read before we commit to a re-conversion of the whole archive, because that re-conversion costs several days of data transfer and has to be done only once. Everything below was verified against the actual files, not against documentation: model configuration read from the wrfout global attributes, and every field checked for real values on four independent timesteps (summer 2019, summer 2024 at 00/06/12/18 UTC, and March 2024) so that fields which exist in the file but are identically zero are not mistaken for usable data.

1. Summary

requested block	verdict
Atmosphere, surface (24 variables + wind shear)	22 of 24 delivered , plus wind shear. Only the two gust components are missing
Atmosphere, pressure levels (9 variables × 13 levels)	all delivered , and both vertical-velocity forms (w in Pa/s and w_z in m/s)
TKE at 3 height levels	not available — the model does not compute it
Static: orography	delivered
Static: land-use / land-cover	partially — dominant category only, not fractions. Fractions obtainable from other files
Land-surface	delivered as the subset that exists, with ERA5 names
Ocean waves (SWH, period, direction, wave-dependent C_d)	not available — no wave model
Sea ice	concentration delivered ; thickness, snow on ice, ice temperature and albedo not available
Surface ocean (SSH, currents, SST)	SST delivered ; SSH and currents not available

2. Why: how the archive is produced

The archive is produced from hourly WRF 4.1.1 output (domain d02, Mercator, 1641×1353 points at 3 km, 49 vertical levels). The relevant configuration is identical across all periods we checked (2019, March 2024, July 2024):

option	value	consequence for this list
BL_PBL_PHYSICS	1 (YSU)	non-local scheme: no prognostic TKE . PBLH was also not written out
KM_OPT	4	no prognostic turbulent kinetic energy array either

option	value	consequence for this list
SF_OCEAN_PHYSICS	0	the ocean is not simulated: no currents, no sea surface height, no mixed layer
(no wave model)	—	no wave fields of any kind, and therefore no wave-dependent drag coefficient
SST_UPDATE	0	SST is constant within each 24 h run , re-initialised at every daily run
CU_PHYSICS	0	convection-permitting: RAINC is identically zero, so total precipitation is complete in RAINNC
MP_PHYSICS	6 (WSM6)	cloud, rain, ice, snow and graupel are available; no hail category
SF_SURFACE_PHYSICS	3 (RUC)	6 soil levels at 0, 5, 20, 40, 160, 300 cm (ERA5 uses 4 layers)
SF_LAKE_PHYSICS, SF_URBAN_PHYSICS	0, 0	no lake model, no urban canopy
ICLOUD	1	the cloud fraction field is binary 0/1 , not fractional

A separate point worth making explicitly: some fields are present in the files but are **identically zero on every timestep we sampled**, and are therefore not usable. These are ACHFX, ACLHF, ACGRDFLX, NOAHRES, SSTS, SST_INPUT, SWNORM, ACSNOW, HAILNC, RAINC, RAINSH, PREC_ACC_C, and the downward longwave at the top of the atmosphere. None of them will be written to the GRIB files.

3. Variables we can obtain by another route

These are not in the model output, but there is a defensible way to get them. None of them is implemented yet: each needs a decision first.

variable	route	confidence	cost
Fractional land cover (forest, crops, urban as fractions), GREENFRAC, soil texture fractions	They exist in the WRF static geo_em_d02 file , which is not part of the hourly output. It is a single file of a few tens of MB	Exact — these are the very fields WRF was initialised with	One request to LRZ, then a one-off ingest. Clearly the best option
10efg, 10nfg (eastward / northward gust components)	Decompose the available gust proxy along the mean wind direction: $10efg = 10fg \cdot U10/ U10 $, likewise for the northward component	Low to medium. The magnitude is a diagnostic, see the caveat in §5; the direction assumption (gust aligned with the mean wind) is standard but crude	Free

variable	route	confidence	cost
Sea-ice surface temperature	Use the skin temperature we already derive, restricted to points where sea-ice concentration > 0	Medium. It is a radiative skin temperature, consistent with the model's own longwave emission, but not a dedicated ice-surface temperature	Free
Surface albedo (including over ice)	Ratio of upward to downward shortwave at the surface, both available	Good during daytime , undefined at night and near sunrise/sunset	Free
Drag coefficient without wave effect	From the model's own roughness length: $C_d = (\kappa / \ln(10/z_0))^2$	Exact — this is precisely the drag the simulation used (Charnock, no wave coupling)	Free
Planetary boundary layer height	Bulk Richardson number on the virtual potential temperature profile; all required fields are present	Reasonable — the same class of diagnostic the model itself would apply	Free

4. Variables we cannot provide

variable	why	the only way to get it
TKE (at any level)	The PBL scheme is YSU, which is non-local and carries no turbulent kinetic energy; the diffusion option does not produce one either. The field does not exist, at any height	Re-run WRF with a TKE-carrying PBL scheme (MYNN or MYJ). A similarity-theory estimate would need boundary-layer height <i>and</i> surface heat flux, both themselves missing, so the errors compound: it would look plausible but would not be consistent with the simulation
Significant wave height, mean wave period, wave direction	No wave model was coupled to the atmosphere	A wave model run, or an external wave reanalysis (ERA5 waves at ~31 km) — which loses exactly the coastal detail that motivates a 3 km product
Drag coefficient including wave effect	Same reason: the surface exchange used Charnock roughness with no sea state	As above. The wave-free drag coefficient <i>is</i> available (§3)
Sea surface height, ocean currents (u, v)	The ocean is not simulated	An ocean reanalysis (e.g. CMEMS), regridded
Sea-ice thickness, snow thickness on sea ice	Not simulated. Sea ice enters only as a concentration boundary field	An external sea-ice product

variable	why	the only way to get it
Sea-ice albedo as a prognostic ice property	Not simulated	Approximable radiatively (§3), but not as an ice-model variable
Snowmelt	The field exists (ACSNOM) but is not a monotone accumulator : individual points drop back to zero within a single run (measured -7.26 mm against 00 UTC on 2024-07-01), so it cannot be referred to 00 UTC the way the other accumulations are. Published under the ERA5 name it would be wrong	Would need the melt diagnosed per timestep inside the model
Surface sensible and latent heat flux	The instantaneous fields were not written out, and the accumulated ones are identically zero in every file we checked	Partially reconstructable from the surface energy budget, but the ground heat flux is also missing, leaving two unknowns in one equation. Best treated as unavailable
Skin temperature as a model variable	TSK was not written out	We already provide skt, obtained by inverting the upward longwave flux (see §5)

5. Caveats on the variables we *do* provide

These matter for correct use and should be read together with the variable list.

- **Cloud cover is built from a binary cloud field.** The model's cloud fraction is 0 or 1 at each level. Total, high, medium and low cloud cover are computed from it with maximum-random overlap, so the column values are fractional and well behaved, but they inherit a cloud field that has no sub-grid fractional information.
- **SST is constant within each day.** Each daily run is initialised with a fixed sea surface temperature and does not update it. The field therefore has a daily, not hourly, time resolution.
- **Skin temperature is derived, not modelled.** It is obtained by inverting the upward long-wave flux assuming an emissivity of 0.98.
- **Soil layers are a mapping, not an identity.** The land-surface scheme uses 6 levels at 0, 5, 20, 40, 160 and 300 cm; ERA5 uses 4 layers at 0-7, 7-28, 28-100 and 100-289 cm. We map the first four onto the ERA5 names; the two deepest levels have no ERA5 counterpart and are not written.
- **Convective inhibition is not defined everywhere.** By construction it is only computed where CAPE exceeds 100 J/kg, and CAPE itself is undefined at the few percent of points with no equilibrium level. We write **zero** at those points rather than a missing value, so that the fields stay dense; zero is also the physically correct reading (no inhibition, no available energy). If you would rather have them flagged as missing, say so now.
- **CAPE and CIN are most-unstable**, computed from the 500 m deep parcel with the highest equivalent potential temperature in the lowest 3 km — not surface-based.
- **The gust field is not a gust parameterisation.** It is the maximum of the *resolved* 10 m wind speed over the output hour. It behaves like a gust and is the best proxy available, but it is not produced by a gust scheme.

- **Rainfall excludes snow and graupel, not hail.** The microphysics has no hail category, so rain is total precipitation minus snow minus graupel.
 - **2 m dewpoint is now in kelvin.** The previous GRIB1 archive wrote it in degrees Celsius under a parameter that ECMWF defines in kelvin. If you read 2d from the old files, it needs +273.15.
 - **Accumulated fields are referred to 00 UTC of the same day,** not to the start of the model run. They are exactly zero at 00 UTC. In the GRIB files they carry a 0-to-H accumulation step with a 00 UTC reference time, so the validity time is the timestep itself. The 10 m wind maximum is the exception: it covers the preceding hour only, because the model resets it at every output.
 - **Geolocation is now exact to ~2 m.** The grid declares the spherical earth of radius 6370 km that WRF actually integrates on. The previous GRIB1 files could not express this and were off by up to ~1.1 km at the northern edge of the domain.
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6. What we need from you

1. **The land-surface list.** The original proposal was lost. We are currently delivering the subset that exists in the output, under ERA5 names: soil moisture and soil temperature (4 layers), snow depth and density, snowfall, snowmelt, surface and sub-surface runoff, skin reservoir content, vegetation cover and leaf area index, vegetation and soil type, friction velocity and surface roughness. Please confirm or amend.
2. **Should we request the static geo_em file from LRZ?** It is the clean way to get fractional land cover, and it is cheap. Without it, land cover is a dominant-category field only.
3. **Are the gust components needed as components,** given that only a magnitude proxy exists? If the decomposition in §3 is acceptable we can produce them; otherwise we deliver the magnitude only.
4. **Is TKE a requirement or a preference?** If it is a requirement, it changes the nature of the project: it means re-running the simulation, not re-processing its output.
5. **Wind shear: which definition?** We currently assume the bulk 10 m to 100 m shear. Any other definition (fixed layers, per pressure level, 0-6 km bulk) is a one-line change, but it has to be decided before the archive is re-converted.